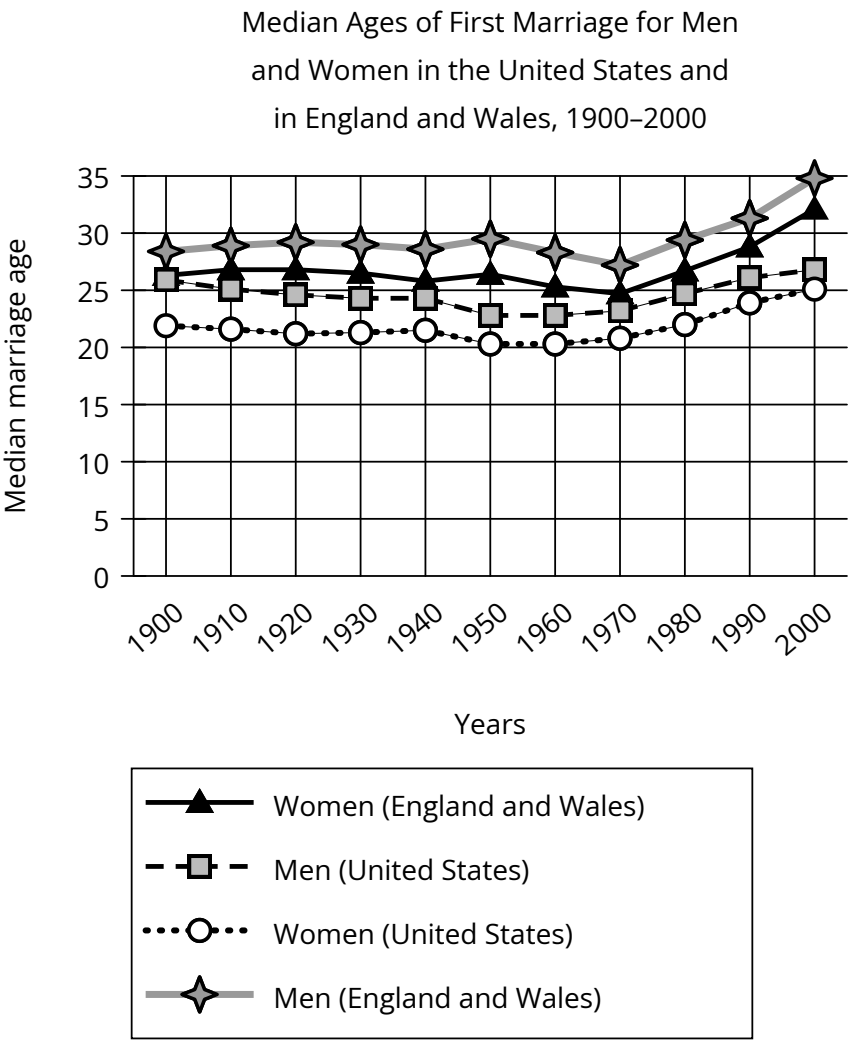


Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	Hard

Question



A sociology student is reading an essay on the median age of first marriage in Western countries throughout the twentieth century. The author of the essay cites factors common to these countries that the author believes caused an increase in the median age of first marriage, such as new technologies that shortened the time needed for domestic chores, making two-person households less necessary and living alone more viable. The student asserts that beyond these factors there must be additional ones specific to particular Western countries that influenced the increase of age at first marriage.

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph that support the student’s assertion?

Answer

- A. Between 1970 and 2000, the median age of first marriage rose more sharply for men in England and Wales than it did for men in the United States.
- B. In England and Wales, the median age of first marriage was consistently higher for men than for women between 1900 and 2000, but this was not always the case in the United States.
- C. The median age of first marriage for men in England and Wales was lower in 1970 than in 1950 or 1990.

D. Between 1900 and 2000, the median age of first marriage for women in England and Wales was consistently higher than for women in the United States, as was the case for men.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The student concluded that country-specific factors influence changes to median age of first marriage. This choice describes a time period when the rate of change differed between countries, suggesting that country-specific factors may have played a role in these changes.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice misreads the graph. The median age of first marriage was consistently higher for men than for women in the United States during the time period depicted. Choice C is incorrect. The student concluded that country-specific factors influence changes to median age of first marriage. However, this choice doesn't provide any contrasts between countries and thus doesn't support the idea of country-specific factors influencing median age of first marriage. Choice D is incorrect. The students' conclusion is about changes that occurred during the 20th century. This choice provides broad information about the century as a whole, so it doesn't give insight into how median age at first marriage changed over time.